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By Tommaso Lecca · Aug 17, 2026, 4:50 PM · [View in your browser](#)

BRUSSELS — European air traffic delays dropped sharply this summer compared with last year, but airlines say that's still nowhere near enough as looming problems in France worry the industry.

Although European air traffic increased by 2.3 percent during the first 10 weeks of the summer season starting on June 1 compared with last year, delays linked to air traffic flow management, or ATFM, fell by 22 percent, according to Eurocontrol , which coordinates national air navigation services across Europe.

Arrival punctuality improved by over 2 percentage points, Eurocontrol said, adding that it expected 24 percent fewer delays this year compared to 2025.

National air navigation service providers, or ANSPs, say the improvement reflects years of effort after the pandemic, including recruiting controllers and advancing technology. There have also been fewer strikes this year.

But airlines disagree with ANSPs over why delay rates remain so high — and how to fix them. They point out that last year there were 18.4 million minutes of ATFM delays, up from 14.2 million minutes in 2015. They want continued reforms to bring delays back to last decade's levels.

"Air travel is still experiencing significantly more ATFM delays than in 2015. This has cost airlines and passengers an estimated €17.5 billion since 2015 (in 2025 prices), of which over 70 percent is linked to capacity shortages and staffing issues," said Neva Sadikoglu Novaky, head of the EU office of the International Air Transport Association, an airline lobby.

"Europe's air traffic management system continues to face structural challenges," she said. "One strong summer does not mean these have been resolved."

The industry is calling for rules allowing overflights to continue even if there is a national air traffic controllers strike. It also wants the European Commission to tackle the EU airspace fragmentation and to address severe controller shortages.

"These delay reductions largely reflect short-term measures by ANSPs and airlines working together," said Ourania Georgoutsakou, managing director of the Airlines for Europe lobby. "But these measures fall short of the substantive air traffic control reform needed."

The French factor

Then there's France — slammed by many airlines for its frequent air traffic controller strikes that cause havoc across Europe. Last year, Michal O'Leary, the boss of Ryanair, denounced a two-day strike , calling it "indefensible."

Eurocontrol said France accounted for 36 percent of all ATFM delays in Europe last year, more than any other country. France's top auditor last month found the country's air traffic control was expensive, plagued by strikes, rigidly organized and ill-prepared for the future.

A recent French Senate report concluded that the country's air navigation service provider has "the worst performance in Europe."

This year has been much calmer — one reason for the fall in delays.

However, the improvement shown this summer still falls short of EU goals.

The EU wants ATFM delays to average no more than 0.7 minutes per flight in 2026, while Eurocontrol told POLITICO that capacity and staffing constraints generated 1.4 minutes of delay per flight during the week of Aug. 3-9.

But air navigation service providers consider EU targets to be part of the problem.

"While European traffic numbers have now surpassed 2019 levels and healthy revenue has returned, EU regulation of the air traffic management sector still prioritises long-term cost cutting," said Enrico Parini, director of European affairs at CANSO Europe, the lobby representing ANSPs.

"From an air traffic management point of view, we have concerns about restrictions on what ANSPs can invest," he added, calling for the next EU performance and funding scheme "to support ANSP investment in future airspace capacity above cost efficiency savings."

Returning to pre-pandemic staffing has proved difficult. Collapsing traffic forced many ANSPs to freeze recruitment and reduce spending, leaving controllers overstretched once demand returned. It can take two to three years to recruit and train new controllers.

"Air traffic controllers are continuing to make every effort to maintain safety and performance, but fatigue and stress are also realities that cannot be overlooked," said Jean-Denis Larrere, president of the Air Traffic Controllers European Unions Coordination.

France could also be a problem in any effort to cut delays. About a third of France's air traffic controllers are set to retire between 2029 and 2035, the Senate report found, which could lead to structural cancellations across the continent.

"Without urgent reform, France will no longer be able to handle flight demand by 2030," warned Neal McMahon, Ryanair's chief operations officer, calling for the country to ramp up recruitment of controllers, modernize its technology and ensure that cross-continental flights can continue across France even if controllers strike.

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